in Mumbai. They remain one of the country's most successful business communities.

In addition to slaves and merchants, there were several other Indian groups in the Middle East during this period, including mercenaries. According to the oral tradition of the Mohyal Brahmins of Punjab, some of their ancestors died fighting for Hussein in the Battle of Karbala, Iraq, in 680 AD. This is why this group of Hindus, also known as Husseini Brahmins, still join Shia Muslims during the ritual mourning of Muharram every year. [8] Such are the complex twists and turns of human history.

At about the same time, another group from central India travelled west, across the Middle East, to Europe. We know them today as the Gypsies or the Roma. The link between the Roma and India has long been debated on linguistic and cultural grounds, but genetic studies have now confirmed it. [9] We do not know why this group left the subcontinent, but it is possible that they were a group of stranded soldiers from the Gujara–Pratihara armies fighting the Turks and Arabs in Sindh. Alternatively, they may have always been a nomadic group that the circumstances of history caused to drift ever westwards. In 1971, at the World Romani Conference near London, the Roma adopted a blue and green flag for their nomadic nation. At the centre of the flag, they placed a wheel—the symbol of the Chakravartin. In some ways, the Roma have the greatest claim to this symbol, for their wheels can truly roll in all directions.

Of course, the exchange of goods, people and ideas was not just with the outside world. There was a great deal of internal exchange, with several examples of how ideas emanating from one part of India spread quickly across the rest of the country during this period. The eighth-century philosopher Adi Shankaracharya, for instance, was from Kerala in the extreme south, but he travelled all over the country. His ideas would become very influential across the subcontinent and beyond.

Similarly, the Shakti tradition associated with the worship of Goddess Durga and her incarnations originated in ancient times in the eastern provinces of Bengal and Assam. However, by the medieval period, the